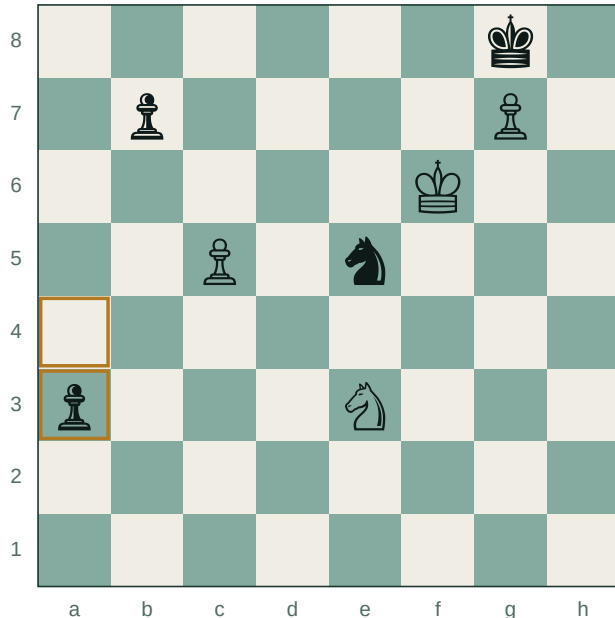


Knight-ending routes: White, move 57

Knight-ending routes

White to move



Previous move: 56...a3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

57. Kxe5 a2 58. Nc2 a1=Q+ 59. Nxa1

57.Kxe5 The king captures the knight on e5. Recorded reply: **57...a2**.

58.Nc2 The knight moves from e3 to c2. Recorded reply: **58...a1=Q+**.

59.Nxa1 The knight captures the queen on a1.

At the end, nominal material is White 5 / Black 1 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from +0 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Knight endings reward exact route calculation. Forks can change a pawn race, while a distant passer may outrun the knight's short-range movement.

HOW TO LOOK

Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: knight on e5. Check for tactical protection.